

2 MANAGING A BLOG

Starting a blog might seem like one of the simplest things to do. After all, all you need is a web page that you can type your thoughts out on. Earlier, when blogging wasn't so prolific, people had to create their own HTML pages, find a web site that would be kind enough to host it for them (at a nominal cost, or preferably free) – (remember the days of Geocities) and then try and make the blog interactive. Because a blog's just not about the content anymore, it's also about the packaging. This is where WordPress scores. For those of you who found the earlier chapter slightly mind-boggling, the best alternative is to zoom over to <http://www.wordpress.com>, (it's wordpress.org for the downloadable version which you'd like to host on your system). Create an account and start blogging on a blog hosted by WordPress. In terms of usability, there is no difference between wordpress.com and wordpress.org. The interface is identical.

2.1 Signing up for a blog

Signing up is ridiculously simple. You're asked to create a user name, protect it with a password, and provide an e-mail address, for mails, verifications and other formalities. Of course, the mail is also how you are notified of posts and comments made on your blog. Sign up for your blog while you're at it.

If you're too unsure about the name, don't be, there's nothing limiting you to only one blog, and many bloggers have been known to change the names and domains of their blog on a whim. One of the good things about WordPress is that it's completely open, and there's no lock-in. That is, assuming you are dissatisfied with Wordpress and would prefer Tumblr, Posterous, Blogger, or any other service, you can export everything to an xml file and import it later on to your new blog.

Choose a blog name and you are good to go. While signing up, make sure you check the box for "I would like my blog to appear in search engines likes Google and Technorati, and in public listings around WordPress.com". Though you have a long way to go in case you want to improve search optimisation, this is a must in case you want your content to be discoverable. Technorati searches blogs and also rates them.

2.2 Creating a profile

A profile is important. Depending on the content of your blog, your